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Affect regulation strategies and perceived emotional adjustment for negative and positive affect: A study on anger, sadness and joy

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This study examines affect regulation and adaptive goals with regard to negative and positive emotional episodes. A sample of 355 undergraduate students were asked to recall an important past-year interpersonal episode of joy, anger, and sadness. Participants reported how they regulated mood and emotions associated with those episodes, filling in an expanded version of Larsen and Prizmic's Measure of Affect Regulation Styles and also responded to measures of perceived attainment of adaptive goals for each emotional episode and psychological well-being. Affect regulation based on gratitude/self-reward, reappraisal, helping others, and seeking informative and emotional social support showed similarly high frequencies in all emotional episodes. Problem-directed action and planning, low withdrawal, seeking instrumental social support, reappraisal, rumination, active physiological regulation, gratitude/self-reward, acceptance/self-control and regulated emotional expression were related to perceived improvement in adaptive goals in all episodes. Seeking emotional and informative social support, spiritual activities, and humor were associated with adaptive goals in anger and joy. Suppression was dysfunctional in sadness and anger episodes, whereas isolation was only in anger episode. Distraction, wishful thinking, venting and confrontation were functional only in joy episode. Overall, these strategies were congruently associated with dispositional suppression and re-evaluation and psychological well-being. Regulation was globally higher in sadness and anger episodes, but venting and expression of humor and affection were higher in joy. Correlations between affect regulation strategies and adaptive goals were stronger in joy. Regulation of positive emotion is discussed as less intense but more successful than in the case of negative emotion. However, the core of adaptive regulation is importantly common to positive and negative affect.

Keywords: positive affect; negative affect; regulation strategies; emotional regulation; psychological well-being

Although affect regulation has been usually studied in the context of negative emotions, positive affect is assumed to be regulated to some extent as well (Mikolajczak, 2009; Parrot, 1993). Research has demonstrated that among all the episodes of emotional regulation over the past two weeks, 81% of the episodes were focused on negative emotions, but still 9% of episodes referred to positive emotions (Gross, Richards, & John, 2006). In another study, 84% of individuals reported more regulation of negative than positive emotions, but importantly 16% indicated greater regulation of positive than negative emotions (Gross et al., 2006). Prizmic (1997, quoted in Larsen & Prizmic, 2008) found that 91% of interviewed participants reported that they had tried positive affect regulation strategies, usually in efforts to maintain or induce positive emotions. These findings suggest that positive emotion regulation is a common phenomenon. The ability to regulate positive emotions could be of particular relevance for well-being (e.g. Tugade & Fredrickson, 2007).

Although the majority of forms of mood regulation have been applied to the management of negative affect (Agoustone & Hemenover, 2008; Compass, Connor-Smith, Saltzman, Thomsen, & Wadsworth, 2001; Connor-Smith & Flachsbart, 2007; Skinner, Edge, Altman, & Sherwood, 2003), there are also equivalents for the regulation of positive affect (Nelis, Quoidbach, Hansenne, & Mikolajczak, 2011; Quoidbach, Berry, Hansenne, & Mikolajczak, 2010; Tkach & Lyubomirsky, 2006). Some authors distinguish strategies for managing positive emotions from negative emotional regulation (Quoidbach et al., 2010); others, such as Gross et al. (2006), examining reappraisal and suppression for both positive and negative emotions. The present study applies the same strategies of regulation to both positive and negative affect and analyzes their relation to psychological well-being.

In the following sections, we review the literature on different strategies for regulation of positive and negative affect and their association with well-being, following the taxonomy of regulation by (1) modification of situation,

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(2) attentional deployment and attribution of meaning, and (3) response modulation and regulation of emotional expression, as proposed by Gross et al. (2006). We briefly describe each strategy and, first, its effects of this strategy on well-being for negative affect, and, second, the effects on well-being for positive affect.

Selection and modification of situation and affect regulation

Selection of situation was not included in this study, because this strategy implies avoiding situations that induce negative affect or selecting some types of positive situations, and we were interested in the regulation of activated affect. Moreover, the planning facet of modification of situation strategy of regulation partially includes this form of affect regulation.

Modification of situation is a psychological process similar to functional problem-focused coping strategy and decreases negative affect (Compass et al., 2001; Skinner et al., 2003). Problem-directed action and planning how to avoid problems or how to maintain and create positive events, as the first type of strategy based on situation modification, was found to be associated with dispositional happiness (Tkach & Lyubomirsky, 2006) and with positive affect (Larsen & Prizmic, 2008; Moskowitz, Hult, Bussolari, & Acree, 2009).

Withdrawing from the situation, or psychological abandonment, is the opposite of modification of situation and usually leads to dysfunctional outcomes for negative affect episodes and also results in lower positive affect (Moskowitz et al., 2009; Ntoumanis & Biddle, 1998). Individuals with a flourishing state of well-being use less avoidance strategies as a form of emotional regulation (Barber, Baggsey, & Munz, 2010).

Indirect modification of a situation would in turn involve seeking social support or asking for the intervention of others. Seeking social support is adaptive for negative affect, particularly when coupled with instrumental responses (Skinner et al., 2003). An affiliative factor including seeking social support was found to be associated with dispositional happiness (Tkach & Lyubomirsky, 2006). Individuals are happier and enjoy themselves more when they are accompanied than when they are alone (Fredrickson, 2009).

Finally, helping others and altruistic or pro-social behavior are forms of functional regulation for negative affect (Skinner et al., 2003), and performing acts of kindness is associated with positive affect (Lyubomirsky, King, & Diener, 2005).

In a similar way as psychological abandonment, the abandonment of social relationships or social isolation is an avoidant dysfunctional form of regulation for negative affect (Larsen & Prizmic, 2008) and is related to low-positive affect (Moskowitz et al., 2009).

Attention deployment and affect regulation

Affect regulation does not necessarily imply a direct solution to a situation being confronted but can aim to only change how a person perceives, construes and reacts to an emotional situation (Gross et al., 2006). Such attentional deployment strategy is functional, includes mainly distraction or removing oneself cognitively and behaviorally from the negative emotional episode (Augustine & Hemenover, 2009), through engaging in activities and thoughts unrelated to the present situation and focusing on alternative positive stimuli. Distraction activities that are rewarding in themselves and that involve some degree of activity produce positive emotions (Larsen & Prizmic, 2004). Nevertheless, distraction in the case of positive emotions was found to be negatively related to positive affect (Quoidbach et al., 2010), suggesting that distraction from a positive episode could erode affect (Fredrickson, 2009).

Strategies such as acceptance and being present also may fall under attentional deployment. There is empirical evidence that regulation of feelings based on acceptance or learning to live with and accept the reality of an emotional event is functional in the case of negative affect (Aldao, Nolen-Hoeksema, & Schweizer, 2010). The form of regulation, which consists in 'being present,' experiencing the moment of joy or calmness, concentrating on the here-and-now, is also a way of reinforcing positive emotions (Fredrickson, 2009; Quoidbach et al., 2010). Finally, a factor including acceptance and enjoyment of positive events was found associated with dispositional happiness (Tkach & Lyubomirsky, 2006).

However, individuals may also regulate emotions and affect by modifying how they think about a situation in order to increase or decrease emotional reactions – changing the meaning of situation.

Cognitive change and affect regulation

In a similar way as acceptance and being present, cognitive change can be considered as a functional form of affect regulation by positive reappraisal understood as perceiving the positive aspects of events and behaviors (Larsen & Prizmic, 2008). Research has confirmed that reappraisal is associated with low-negative affect and also with positive affect (Nezlek & Kuppens, 2008). Feeling grateful for the good things in life could be also considered as a form of cognitive reappraisal, because it implies perceiving a situation in a positive way, more than modifying it or an emotional response to the situation. Importantly, gratitude was found to be more frequent in persons with high well-being (Barber et al., 2010). Likewise, seeking meaning through religion (reading about or doing spiritual activities) is also an instance of positive reappraisal, related to low-negative affect and also positive affect (Moskowitz et al., 2009).

In contrast, rumination, or repetitive thinking on the causes and consequences of emotions, intensifies emotion in general and is considered a dysfunctional form of regulation in the case of negative affect. While a lot of studies usually find a negative association of rumination with affect (Aldao et al., 2010; Compass et al., 2001), a meta-analysis of experimental induction of affect regulation detected a positive effect of rumination (Augustine & Hemenover, 2009), probably because it was related to emotional processing. In the case of positive emotional episodes, rumination may well increase positive affect because it maintains and increases emotional reactions (Rimé, 2009). Ruminative response to positive affect was demonstrated to have beneficial effects on self-esteem (Feldman, Joorman, & Johnson, 2008), and regulation by 'mental travel' to a positive past or reminiscences is also associated with positive affect (Quoidbach et al., 2010). Repetitive thinking can also be conceived as a form of emotional processing similar to rumination. Finally, trying to understand and analyze feelings, or reflexive rumination, was more frequent among those with high well-being (Barber et al., 2010). However, another study revealed that thinking a great deal in an analytical way about a positive episode (trying to carefully understand and explain why and how the positive fact or event occurred) results in a reduction in pleasure stemming from a positive emotional event (Fredrickson, 2009).

Social comparison is another cognitive process associated with emotion regulation through attentional deployment (Rimé, 2009). Downward social comparison is assumed to have positive affective influence in the case of negative affectively loaded episodes, and upward social comparison is expected to have motivational positive effect – but the evidence is ambivalent. Moreover, people who often *compare* themselves with others are less happy (Fujita, 2008). People with 'flourishing well-being' also use less social comparison as a form of emotional regulation (Barber et al., 2010).

Finally, wishful thinking or dreaming of being in a positive situation is in turn a cognitive avoidant dysfunctional strategy of regulation for negative affect (Connor-Smith & Flachsbart, 2007; Skinner et al., 2003). However, wishful thinking in the case of positive emotions is similar to 'positive mental travel' to the future, and this strategy is associated with positive affect (Quoidbach et al., 2010).

Response modification and affect regulation: internal and overt interpersonal reactions

Whereas the previously described clusters of affect regulation strategies imply modification of situation, attentional deployment or of its cognitive perception, response modulation includes modification of physiological reactions. Passive physiological regulation of emotions by eating, drinking, or sleeping is an avoidant dysfunctional response to negative affect (Connor-Smith & Flachsbart, 2007), related to low-positive affect (Moskowitz et al.,

2009). In contrast, active physiological regulation by exercise or relaxation is functional, decrease negative affect and emotion, as well as improves personal affect and energy (Biddle & Ekkekakis, 2006; Thayer, 1998).

In turn, self-control that consists in trying not to act immediately, delaying the response instead (Connor-Smith & Flachsbart, 2007), is another adaptive form of response modulation in the case of negative affect (Vaillant, 2004). Self-control was found to be associated with dispositional happiness (Tkach & Lyubomirsky, 2006). Because this response is empirically associated with acceptance (Páez, Martínez-Sánchez, Sevillano, Mendiburo, & Campos, 2012b), related to attentional deployment, this item was integrated in this strategy.¹

Self-rewarding, seeking alternative rewards actually or in the mind, is a functional form of regulation of negative affect (Larsen & Prizmic, 2008). Focusing on positive aspects of life reinforce positive affect (Fredrickson, 2009). Because this response was associated in previous studies with gratitude (Páez, Mendiburo & Martínez-Sánchez, 2012a), partially embedded in reappraisal, the items were integrated in this strategy (as suggested by reviewers).

Activation of positive emotions, such as affection and humor, is also functional forms of regulation used to control especially negative feelings like anger (Kennedy-Moore & Watson, 1999). Humor involving laughing at one's own mistakes or faults and those of others, but without scorn, seeking merely to lighten the mood, is associated with psychological well-being (Martin, 2007). Warm and humorous interactions were found to be clearly related to positive affect (Fredrickson, 2009; Martin, 2007).

Another strategy of response regulation is focused on interpersonal and expressive responses. This type of regulation of expressive reactions includes mainly venting or the strong nonverbal and behavioral expression of emotions (Augustine & Hemenover, 2009), dysfunctional forms of regulation in negative affect (Larsen & Prizmic, 2008; Penley, Tomaka, & Wiebe, 2002). A related form of expressive regulation is confrontation, which involves the expression of emotion to those responsible for the negative emotions, with the aim of changing what happened. This form is usually dysfunctional or neutral in the case of negative affect (Penley et al., 2002). Because strong expression of an emotion intensifies it, strong displays of positive emotions are associated with positive affect (Quoidbach et al., 2010), and confrontation would probably have the same incremental effect in the case of positive emotional episodes.

Social sharing or verbal expression of emotion also reinforces both positive and negative affect (Rimé, 2009). Studies on social sharing and 'capitalization' of positive emotions have shown that sharing a positive event and verbalizing about it lead to an increase in positive affect that goes beyond the impact of the experience itself and amplifies it (Rimé, 2009), particularly if there

is an active and constructive response from the context (Larsen & Prizmic, 2008). Talking to someone as a form of emotional regulation is less frequent among individuals with low well-being (Barber et al., 2010), and capitalizing is associated with greater positive affect (Quoidbach et al., 2010). Social sharing could imply a regulated expression of emotion, a functional form of regulation (Stanton, Kirk, Cameron, & Danoff-Burg, 2000), probably also in the case of positive affect.

Finally, inhibition of feelings and suppression of expression are dysfunctional forms of emotional regulation for negative affect (Gross et al., 2006), and people with 'flourishing well-being' use less suppression as a form of emotional regulation (Barber et al., 2010). Suppression was associated with low-positive affect when it implied hidden positive emotions (Nezlek & Kuppnes, 2008; Quoidbach et al., 2010), although a study by Christophe, Antoine, Leroy, and Delelis (2009) failed to find an association between suppression and positive affect.

Objectives of the study

The aim of the present research is to examine the regulation of positive and negative affect and its effects for well-being. Most previous studies have addressed the topic of the regulation of negative or ambivalent stressful events (but see Nezlek & Kuppens, 2008; Quoidbach et al., 2010), whereas this study will focus on the regulation of both negative and positive emotional events. In addition, whereas previous literature usually has analyzed dispositional regulation strategies (Barber et al., 2010) applied to abstract positive and negative events (Quoidbach et al., 2010), we will explore how individuals apply the same strategies to regulate different emotional episodes: experiences of sadness, anger, and joy.

Based on the previous review, we expect that the following strategies will be functional for both positive and negative emotions: modifying the situation through problem-directed action and planning, seeking social support, attentional deployment, and cognitive change by reappraisal and spiritual activities, acceptance and self-control, gratitude and self-reward, response modulation by active physiological regulation, activation of positive feelings such as affection and humor, and regulated expression. The following strategies will be functional only in the case of positive emotions because they amplify emotional reaction: rumination, wishful thinking or positive mental travel to the past and future, venting, confrontation, and social sharing will be functional during an emotional episode of joy. Psychological abandonment, social isolation, social comparison and suppression are supposed to be dysfunctional in general because they decrease positive and increase negative affect. Finally, distraction may divert attention from positive events and erode positive affect, but it can also be a source of reinforcing positive affect.

Also expected are congruent relations between the use of functional and dysfunctional strategies in episodes of joy and dispositional indicators of emotional regulation and psychological well-being.

Finally, we shall test for gender differences. Research has found small differences of affective regulation between the two genders, women reporting greater use of support-seeking, rumination and venting than men, while men report greater avoidance and physiological forms of regulation than women (Brody & Hall, 2008).

Method

Participants

A total of 355 students (72.2% women) from four different Spanish Universities, and with a mean age of 24 years ($SD=8.5$), took part in the study during practical sessions that formed part of their respective courses. All received course credits for their participation. All participants were born in Spain or lived there for many years and were fluent in Spanish.

Procedure

Participants were recruited from local universities, where research assistants administered the questionnaire during lectures. Undergraduates filled in the questionnaires in exchange for credits in various psychology courses in the years 2010 and 2011. Completion of the questionnaire was mandatory for the courses.

First, participants were asked to select and describe an event that had caused them (1) anger, (2) sadness, and (3) joy in the last 12 months, choosing from a list of 12 life change episodes. The list included both positive joyful events, such as making a new friend or initiating an intimate relationship, a success in studies or at work, and success in personal matters and/or relationships, as well negative events like problems with personal relationships, studies, or work, diseases and deaths, related either to anger or sadness. All participants responded with respect to each of the three emotional episodes in randomized order. With regard to each of the emotional events, they were instructed to provide information on the type of event and to inform when they had occurred. Then, they responded to the Measure of Affect Regulation Styles (MARS) in relation to each specific emotional event. Finally, participants were asked to indicate the extent to which they felt they had achieved different emotional and social outcomes by means of regulation. Different orders of presentation of the episodes of joy, anger, and sadness had no effect at all on the results. The data from the well-being and dispositional emotional regulation scales were collected in the class sessions two weeks prior to the participants' filling out the MARS scale.

Table 1. Descriptive statistics for each item (range 0–6).

Item	Anger		Sadness		Joy	
	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>
<i>Modification of situation</i>						
Problem-directed action						
04. I made a plan or resolution to change this situation	3.86	1.83	3.49	1.96	2.14	2.08
05. I took action to solve the problem causing my mood	4.07	1.73	3.83	1.75	2.26	2.16
06. I made a plan or resolution to avoid such problems in the future or to maintain a positive situation	4.22	1.75	3.68	1.95	3.69	2.10
Withdrawal						
07. I withdrew from or avoided the situation	1.97	1.67	1.56	1.74	0.76	1.41
08. I carried on as if nothing had happened	1.78	1.72	1.70	1.79	1.17	1.65
09. I gave up, did nothing; I did not attempt to control the situation	1.33	1.54	1.29	1.57	1.18	1.70
35. I tried to accept it as my fate: what will be, will be	2.93	2.02	3.40	1.94	2.87	2.28
Social isolation						
13. I withdrew from or avoided the persons related to the situation	2.54	2.07	1.77	1.96	0.82	1.43
14. I kept myself to myself, I wanted to be alone	2.30	2.04	2.32	2.04	0.94	1.59
Altruism						
41. I went out of my way to help someone	2.16	1.83	2.08	1.85	1.97	1.94
Emotional social support						
52. I talked to someone about my feelings	4.12	1.81	3.86	1.97	4.00	1.91
53. I spoke in order to get understanding and support	3.86	1.95	3.69	1.90	3.16	2.20
Instrumental social support						
54. I talked to someone in order to resolve or improve the situation that triggered my mood	3.23	2.10	3.03	2.14	2.25	2.25
Informative social support						
55. I talked to an advisor or counselor	3.62	2.01	3.45	2.08	2.95	2.26
56. I asked someone who had faced a similar problem or situation what they did	2.64	2.15	2.90	2.13	2.64	2.26
<i>Attentional deployment and cognitive change</i>						
Rumination						
01. I thought about how I could have done things differently	3.60	1.75	3.26	2.01	2.29	2.01
02. I tried to understand my feelings by thinking about and analyzing them	4.29	1.59	4.15	1.67	3.43	2.04
03. I thought quickly about what had happened, about the emotional effects of the situation	4.28	1.55	4.13	1.69	4.03	1.84
Distraction						
21. I did something fun, something I really enjoy	4.01	1.85	3.61	1.82	3.78	2.00
22. I watched TV, read a book, etc., for distraction	3.87	1.90	3.55	1.85	2.91	2.01
23. I worked on something or stayed busy to forget my mood	3.50	1.85	3.49	1.86	1.73	1.89
24. I thought about something to distract myself from my feelings	3.56	1.78	3.55	1.70	1.47	1.81
25. I socialized to forget my mood	3.84	1.75	3.76	1.72	1.93	2.09
Acceptance and self-control						
32. I counted to 10 before answering, in an effort to avoid overflowing emotionally, to control my reaction	2.74	2.02	2.59	2.07	2.07	2.05
33. I wrote about what had happened to me, about the feelings it triggered in me, in an effort to avoid overflowing emotionally, to control my reaction	1.63	2.01	1.77	2.01	1.45	1.95
34. I accepted and endured the situation, trying to get on with normal life	4.06	1.60	4.35	1.55	3.28	2.30
Wishful thinking						
29. I daydreamed about the time when I will feel better than today	3.01	2.08	3.30	2.03	1.98	2.04
Spiritual activities						
36. I tried to cope spiritually, put my faith in God, or did something religious	1.56	2.04	1.76	2.12	1.80	2.15
40. I read or did something religious, of a spiritual nature	1.14	1.73	1.33	1.87	1.53	1.95

(Continued)

Table 1. (Continued)

Item	Anger		Sadness		Joy	
	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>
Reappraisal						
37. I tried to reinterpret the situation, to find a different meaning	3.24	1.91	3.18	1.93	2.50	2.16
38. I tried to put things in perspective	3.72	1.79	3.77	1.76	3.52	2.03
39. I tried to find something good in the situation	3.26	2.04	3.31	1.99	4.33	4.47
Social comparison						
42. I compared myself to people who are worse off	2.10	1.98	1.84	1.87	1.61	1.93
Gratitude and self-reward						
28. I treated myself to something special	2.83	1.90	2.85	1.84	3.15	2.09
30. I tried to think about those things that are going well for me	3.75	1.70	3.59	1.71	3.82	2.00
31. I tried to be grateful for the things in my life that are going well	4.10	1.72	4.08	1.71	4.41	1.87
Response Modulation						
Inhibition and suppression						
10. I tried not to think about what had happened, to ignore the emotions I was feeling	2.03	1.77	1.97	1.74	1.02	1.50
11. I tried to not let my feelings show, to suppress any expression	2.35	1.95	2.37	2.02	1.20	1.64
12. I faked, or expressed emotions opposite to those I was feeling	1.81	1.82	1.98	1.96	0.99	1.53
Active physiological regulation						
15. I played sports, exercised	2.29	2.05	1.83	1.97	1.85	2.03
16. I practised relaxation, meditation	1.82	1.91	1.76	1.88	1.67	1.97
Passive physiological regulation						
17. I slept or took a nap	2.34	2.05	2.31	2.11	1.78	2.05
18. I ate something to get over my bad mood	2.16	1.99	2.17	2.08	1.92	3.77
19. I drank coffee or caffeinated beverages	1.78	2.11	1.72	2.09	1.69	2.12
20. I used alcohol to get out of a bad mood	1.04	1.59	1.15	1.67	1.21	1.77
Humor						
26. I laughed, joked around, tried to make myself or others laugh	3.39	1.95	3.21	1.91	3.88	1.86
Affection						
27. I expressed myself or behaved more affectionately, sought erotic enjoyment.	1.87	1.70	2.18	1.82	2.95	2.16
Venting						
44. I let my feelings out by venting or expressing them	3.06	1.80	3.14	1.82	3.86	1.90
45. I made my emotion clear, verbalizing it and expressing it as strongly as I could with my face, my gestures and my way of behaving	2.75	1.92	2.49	1.87	3.77	1.83
Confrontation						
46. I expressed my feelings to the person(s) responsible for the situation or tried to get them to change their minds or to improve the situation	3.17	2.14	2.55	2.13	3.38	2.18
47. I spoke sarcastically or ironically to/about the person(s) responsible for the situation	2.18	2.00	1.48	1.83	1.36	1.81
48. I showed my emotions to the person(s) responsible for the situation, behaving differently toward them	2.51	2.02	1.67	1.97	2.64	2.26
Regulated expression						
49. I kept my feelings under control while it was convenient, and later, when they would not make matters worse, I expressed them	3.22	1.82	2.95	1.92	2.74	2.06
50. I wrote about my feelings in a diary, letter, or e-mail	1.42	1.94	1.70	2.09	1.46	2.03
51. I calmly apologized for what was done and said	2.34	1.99	2.00	1.99	1.70	2.04

Instruments

MARS (Larsen & Prizmic, 2004). The MARS scale is originally made up of 32 items, to which a further 24 items were added, generated by the authors on the basis of the previous emotional regulation scales (Quoidbach

et al., 2010; Nezlek & Kuppens, 2008), so as to adequately represent the following forms of emotional regulation: (1) Instrumental or problem-focused regulation (items 4, 5, 6); (2) Psychological abandonment or withdrawal (items 7, 8, 9, 35); (3) Seeking informative

social support (items 52, 53); (4) Seeking emotional social support (items 55, 56); (5) Seeking instrumental social support (item 54); (6) Altruism (item 41); (7) Social isolation (items 13, 14); (8) Positive reappraisal (items 37, 38, 39); (9) Spiritual activities (items 36, 40); (10) Distraction (items 21, 22, 23, 24, 25); (11) Rumination (items 1, 2, 3); (12) Social comparison (items 42, 43); (13) Wishful thinking (item 29); (14) Active physiological regulation (items 15, 16); (15) Passive physiological regulation (items 17, 18, 19, 20); (16) Acceptance and self-control (items 32, 33, 34); (17) Gratitude and self-reward (items 28, 30, 31); (18) Humor (item 26); (19) Affection (item 27); (20) Inhibition and suppression (items 10, 11, 12); (21) Venting (items 44, 45); (22) Confrontation (items 46, 47, 48); and (23) Regulated expression (items 49, 50, 51). A previously validated Spanish version of this scale was applied (Páez et al., 2012b; Páez et al., 2012a). Items were written using neutral wording to be applied to regulation of affect and emotions of positive and negative valence simultaneously (see Table 1). For instance, confrontation and direct action seem to be irrelevant for positive affect episodes, such as these related to joy. However, the neutral formulation of this form of affect regulation stresses the display of emotion in front of others or acting in order to improve situation, which in this case means expressing joy and acting to ameliorate the social milieu and to increase positive affect. Participants did not have problems in responding to the items typically used in the context of negative affect regulation with reference to positive events provoking joy.

The scale was applied to episodes of anger, sadness, and joy, so that emotional regulation strategies were evaluated in response to specific episodes. Previous scales have applied the MARS' items as dispositions (Barber et al., 2010), or participants were asked to respond to generic scenarios (Quoidbach et al., 2010). We opted in turn to evaluate the regulation of specific episodes chosen by participants. This state-type measure provides a more concrete and valid picture of regulation strategies. The instructions requested participants: 'Indicate how often you perform the following actions for regulating/managing the situation and the feelings of joy [anger/sadness] they gave you.' The Likert-type response scale ranged from 0 (never) to 6 (nearly always). Table 1 presents the items and the descriptive statistics per each item.

Perceived attainment of adaptative goals in the episode

In other studies, external judges have assessed the functionality of forms of regulation (Rivers, Brackett, Kotulak, & Salovey 2007). Here, we measured the functionality of strategies by means of seven items inquiring about the extent to which by the end of the episode the respondents had succeeded in achieving some specific adaptive goals. For each episode, participants filled in a measure of perceived attainment of adaptive goals such as: (1) Reducing displeasure, discomfort or discontent-

ment and increasing pleasure, comfort and contentment, that is, changing from displeasure to greater pleasure; (2) Understanding, explaining and being able to predict the situation or conflict; (3) Controlling the emotional experience of the situation; (4) Preserving self-image and social relations (perceived self-efficacy); (4) Controlling or resolving the problem associated with the situation, achieving greater control over it; (5) Managing and improving relations with other people; (6) Maintaining or improving personal image, that is, making one's own self-appraisal more positive. The response scale was Likert-type, from 1 (little or no change) to 10 (changing greatly). Reliability of the scale of perceived adjustment at the end of the episode was high ($\alpha=0.90$ for joy, $\alpha=0.89$ for the anger episode and $\alpha=0.87$ for the sadness episode). A factorial analysis yielded a single factor (data not presented).

The emotion regulation questionnaire (ERQ; Gross & John, 2003)

ERQ is a self-report questionnaire measuring dispositional emotional regulation which consists of two scales corresponding to two different emotion regulation strategies: reappraisal (e.g. 'When I want to feel more positive emotion [such as joy or amusement] I change what I'm thinking about') and expressive suppression (e.g. 'I keep my emotions to myself'). We used a validated Spanish version of this scale (Paez et al., 2012a). Alpha coefficients for reappraisal and suppression were satisfactory in the present sample, .78 and .81, respectively.

Psychological Well-being Scale (Ryff, 1989; adapted to Spanish and validated by Díaz et al. (2005)). Ryff (1989) developed a theoretically based self-report inventory designed to measure six dimensions of psychological well-being (PWB). The six dimensions are self-acceptance, environmental mastery, purpose in life, positive relations with others, personal growth, and autonomy. The reliability in the present sample of the composite PWB score ($\alpha=0.90$) was high.

Results

Descriptive analyses

As episodes of joy, participants selected: making friends or starting up intimate relationships (25.5%), success in studies or at work (25.5%), and success in personal matters and/or relationships (22.0%). These episodes occurred on average in the previous five months. In the case of anger, participants selected as triggers mainly problems related with personal relationships (59.8%) that had occurred on average in the previous five months. As regards sadness episodes, participants selected mainly experiences associated with deaths (28.4%) and personal relationships (31.3%), and which had occurred on average in the previous seven months. Correlations between the strategies used in the three episodes were all signifi-

Table 2. Differential use and of emotional regulation strategies for anger, sadness, and joy episodes and scale reliabilities ($N=165$).

	Anger	Sadness	Joy	F	α	No. of items
<i>Modification of situation</i>						
Problem-Directed Action (4–6)	12.06 ^a	11.20 ^a	8.17 ^b	42.33***	0.82	9
Psychological abandonment (7–9, 35)	8.30 ^a	7.97 ^a	6.48 ^b	13.94***	0.81	12
Social Isolation (13, 14)	5.16 ^a	4.62 ^a	1.78 ^b	89.37***	0.79	6
Altruism (41)	2.34	2.29	2.02	2.31	0.72	3
Seeking Emotional Social Support (52, 53)	7.27	6.97	6.86	1.1	0.88	6
Seeking Informative Social Support (55, 56)	6.10	6.24	5.59	2.51	0.88	6
Seeking Instrumental Social Support (54)	3.10 ^a	2.98 ^a	2.27 ^b	12.54***	0.70	3
<i>Attentional deployment and cognitive change</i>						
Rumination (1–3)	12.51 ^a	11.64 ^a	9.62 ^b	19.54***	0.66	9
Acceptance (32–34)	8.47 ^a	9.00 ^a	7.14 ^b	18.98***	0.81	9
Wishful thinking (29)	3.04 ^a	3.47 ^b	2.05 ^c	28.76***	0.52	3
Doing spiritual things (36, 40)	3.46	3.79	3.79	1.51	0.92	6
Reappraisal (37–39)	12.85	12.99	12.76	0.91	0.80	9
Gratitude (28, 30, 31)	11.21	11.05	11.40	0.91	0.83	9
Social Comparison (42–43)	3.96 ^a	3.41	2.96 ^b	7.19**	0.81	6
<i>Response Modulation</i>						
Active Physiological Regulation (15, 16)	4.46 ^a	4.00	3.74 ^b	4.46**	0.87	6
Passive Physiological Regulation (17–20)	8.17 ^a	8.09	6.90 ^b	4.91**	0.88	12
Humor (26)	3.47	3.27 ^a	3.82 ^b	5.34**	0.62	3
Warmth, affection (27)	1.99 ^a	2.32 ^a	2.93 ^b	18.15***	0.73	3
Inhibition/Suppression (10, 11, 12)	6.78 ^a	6.89 ^a	3.25 ^b	56.29***	0.86	9
Venting (44, 45)	5.59 ^a	5.52 ^a	7.76 ^b	41.92***	0.82	6
Confrontation (46–48)	7.63 ^b	6.19 ^a	7.60 ^b	7.00**	0.77	9
Regulated expression (49–51)	7.15 ^a	6.64	6.17 ^b	4.64**	0.79	9

Notes: * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$.

Emotional regulation strategies shown in italics differed among sub-samples. Different subindices (a, b, c) indicate significant differences among episodes (Bonferroni correction). Items belonging to each emotional regulation strategy are shown in parenthesis.

cant (ranging from 0.32 to 0.80, with mean r equal 0.51), as reflected in the satisfactory global reliabilities of items across the three episodes (alphas between 0.62 and 0.92, see Table 2).

Use of forms of regulation according to emotional episode

ANOVAs with repeated measures in the episode factor were used for evaluating differential use of each one of the forms of regulation according to the emotional episode. In the joy episode, the score was higher for humor, affection, and venting compared with the anger and sadness episodes. Confrontation was higher in both joy and anger than in sadness (see Table 2 for the cell means and *post hoc* test). No significant differences were found for altruism, seeking informative and emotional social support, spiritual activities, cognitive reappraisal or gratitude/self-reward, which were used at a higher level in all emotional episodes, with the exception of spiritual activities that were reported at a lower level, as expected for the case of the secularized current Spanish society. ANOVA's showed that forms of regulation as problem-directed action and planning, seeking instrumental social support, withdrawal, social isolation, rumination, self-control and acceptance, and

inhibition and suppression of expression were more frequent in anger and sadness than in joy episodes. Distraction, social comparison, physiological regulation and regulated expression were higher in anger than in joy. Wishful thinking was higher in sadness.

Gender differences in the use of families of emotional regulation in episodes of joy, anger and sadness

To contrast gender differences point biserial correlation between gender and regulation strategies were ruled (Male=1; Female=2). In the anger episodes, women showed significantly greater use of the following forms of affect regulations than men: problem-focused strategy ($r=0.14$), venting ($r=0.26$), seeking emotional support ($r=0.23$), and seeking informative support ($r=0.19$), $p < 0.05$. On the other hand, men made more use of social isolation ($r=-0.15$), $p < 0.05$ than women. In the sadness episodes, women showed significantly greater use of venting ($r=0.27$) and seeking emotional support ($r=0.17$), $p < 0.05$, compared with men, whereas men used inhibition and suppression ($r=-0.16$) and active physiological regulation ($r=-0.16$), $p < 0.05$, more than women. In the joy episodes, women reported applying more frequently than men affect regulation through venting ($r=0.22$) and seeking emotional support ($r=0.21$), $p < 0.05$, whereas men

Table 3. Correlations between emotional regulation strategies and perceived attainment of adaptive goals in the episode for anger, sadness, and joy.

	Improvement or functional goals		
	Anger	Sadness	Joy
<i>Modification of situation</i>			
Problem-Directed Action	0.26**	0.34***	0.26**
Withdrawal	-0.17**	-0.16**	-0.19**
Isolation	-0.15**	-0.08	-0.11
Altruism	0.04	0.05	0.24**
Seeking Emotional Social Support	0.14*	0.11	0.36***
Seeking Instrumental Social Support	0.27***	0.15*	0.32***
Seeking Informative Social Support	0.21**	0.11	0.35***
<i>Attentional deployment and cognitive change</i>			
Rumination	0.20**	0.13*	0.36***
Distraction	0.08	0.06	0.16*
Acceptance	0.23**	0.19**	0.34***
Wishful thinking	-0.04	0.02	0.24**
Doing spiritual things	0.17*	0.10	0.29***
Reappraisal	0.29***	0.30***	0.37***
Gratitude	0.17**	0.21**	0.34***
Social Comparison	0.05	0.02	-0.03
<i>Response modulation</i>			
Inhibition/Suppression	-0.17**	-0.19**	-0.06
Active Physiological Regulation	0.18**	0.18**	0.30***
Passive Physiological Regulation	-0.01	-0.07	0.27**
Humor	0.12*	0.08	0.22**
Affection	-0.02	0.06	0.04
Venting	0.11	0.08	0.25**
Confrontation	0.09	0.09	0.36***
Regulated expression	0.35***	0.23**	0.22**

Notes: * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$.

Table 4. Correlations between emotional regulation strategies and humor, ERQ, and PWB for joy episode.

	ERQ reappraisal	ERQ suppression	PWB Ryff
<i>Modification of situation</i>			
Problem-Directed Action	0.26*	0.11	0.22*
Psychological abandonment	0.05	0.26*	-0.11
Isolation	-0.04	0.27**	-0.22*
Altruism	0.17*	0.16*	-0.01
Seeking Social Support	0.12	-0.28**	0.18
Seeking Instrumental Social Support	0.18*	-0.02	0.06
Seeking Informative Social Support	0.21*	-0.08	0.19*
<i>Attentional deployment and cognitive change</i>			
Rumination	0.25*	0.06	0.20*
Distraction	0.18*	0.11	-0.09
Gratitude	0.30**	-0.06	0.26*
Wishful thinking	0.19*	0.10	-0.09
Doing spiritual things	0.04	0.10	-0.01
Reappraisal	0.22*	0.12	0.05
Acceptance	0.21*	0.05	0.06
Social Comparison	0.07	0.04	-0.01
<i>Response modulation</i>			
Inhibition/Suppression	-0.01	0.32**	-0.21*
Active Physiological Regulation	0.09	0.07	0.08
Passive Physiological Regulation	0.04	0.18*	0.01
Humor	0.16*	-0.08	-0.01
Affection	0.10	0.04	-0.14
Venting	0.10	-0.20*	0.15
Confrontation	0.05	0.01	0.08
Regulated Expression	0.12	-0.01	-0.03

Notes: * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

showed more abandonment or withdrawal ($r = -0.18$) and social isolation ($r = -0.20$), $p < 0.05$ than women.

Emotional regulation and perceived attainment of adaptive goals in the episode

Forms of regulation were correlated with the attainment of adaptive goals in all three episodes (see Table 3). Problem-directed action and planning, seeking instrumental social support, reappraisal, rumination, active physiological regulation, acceptance and self-control, gratitude and self-reward, and regulated expression, as well as low psychological abandonment or withdrawal, were associated with attainment of adaptive goals in joy, sadness and anger. Isolation was dysfunctional in anger (negatively correlated with attainment of adaptive goals). Seeking emotional and informative support, spiritual activities, and humor were associated with adaptive outcomes in the anger and joy episodes. Altruism, distraction, passive physiological regulation, venting and confrontation regulation were related to attainment of adaptive goals only in the episode of joy.

To test which forms of regulation were more effective for joy than for sadness and anger, correlation values were changed from r to a Z -score, and Z -test for correlations were performed, when correlation were significantly associated with adaptive goals. Seeking emotional social support was more effective in joy than in anger, $p < 0.05$. Rumination was also more effective in joy than in sadness, $p < 0.05$. Acceptance was more effective in joy than in sadness, $p < 0.05$. Spiritual activities were more effective in joy than in anger, $p < 0.05$. Also, gratitude was more effective in joy than in sadness, $p < 0.05$, and than in anger, $p < 0.05$. All the differences comparing anger and sadness were not significant.

Episodic emotional regulation in relation to dispositional regulation and well-being

Functional forms of regulation in joy, such as problem-directed action and planning, seeking emotional and informative instrumental regulation, altruism, rumination, reappraisal, self-control and acceptance, distraction, wishful thinking, and humor were significantly correlated with the dimension of reappraisal of dispositional emotional regulation.

Inhibition and suppression, dysfunctional in the sadness and anger episodes, were associated with dispositional suppression. Psychological abandonment, social isolation, and passive physiological regulation were associated with dispositional suppression as well, whereas seeking emotional support and venting were negatively related to it.

Problem-directed action and planning, seeking informative social support, rumination, self-reward, low social isolation, and low suppression were congruently

associated with at least one dispositional adaptive regulation and with PWB.

Discussion

To our knowledge, this is the first study that compares strategies of emotional regulation in the case of negative and positive episodes – anger and sadness vs. joy – and shows that strategies of regulation are indeed being applied to positive emotions. Moreover, the findings of this investigation reveal that gratitude and self-reward, reappraisal, seeking emotional social support and helping others are used to regulate both positive and negative affect. All such strategies were associated with a positive subjective perception of the attainment of adaptive goals at the end of the episode. This study confirms that both positive and negative affect stimulate the self-regulation process and cognitive work such as reappraisal in general (Rimé, 2009).

The use of strategies to regulate sadness was found to be associated with the regulation of anger, and regulation in the both types of negative episodes was related to the regulation in the case of joy. For instance, use of reappraisal in sadness is linked with re-evaluation on anger and both with the use of reappraisal in joy. Our findings suggest that even if individuals regulate emotions with relatively different strategies, their application is relatively stable (but see Rivers et al., 2007 for more moderate associations).

Gender differences

As regards gender differences, women reported more venting and seeking emotional support overall, and more problem-directed action and planning and seeking informative support in anger, compared with men. Men, on the other hand, reported having used more strategies of social isolation in anger and joy situations, greater use of suppression/inhibition and active physiological regulation in sadness, and greater withdrawal or psychological abandonment in joy, in comparison with women. The differences found were small, explaining between 2 and 4% of variance, and in line with previous studies, there was specifically more externalizing regulation in women and a slight tendency for more avoidance and physiological regulation in men (Brody & Hall, 2008; Thayer, Newman, & McClain, 1994).

Differences in episodic regulation of emotions and the common core of adaptive regulation

As regards the differences in episodic regulation of emotions, problem-directed action and planning, seeking social support, rumination, self-control and acceptance, psychological abandonment, social isolation and suppression were higher in sadness and anger than in joy. Regulated expression, passive physiological regulation

and social comparison were higher in anger than in joy – with no differences in the case of sadness. Finally, wishful thinking was higher in sadness than in joy.

These results suggest that negative affect mobilizes more regulation overall. One explanation of these findings might be that people are relatively more successful at regulating positive affect because most forms of regulation in the case of joy were linked with attainment of adaptive goals and/or well-being (19 of 23 significant correlations between regulations and adjustment for joy), whereas the regulation of negative affect is less successful (15 for anger and 10 for sadness). As regards specific more effective forms of regulation in the case of joy, rumination and acceptance were more effective in joy than in sadness (but not than in anger); seeking emotional social support and spiritual activities were more effective in joy than in anger (although not than in sadness). In turn, gratitude was more effective in joy than both in sadness and anger.

Overall, affect regulation strategies for positive mood are more strongly related to adaptive outcomes than in the case of negative emotions, confirming the importance of maintenance and modification of positive emotions for well-being. It is fair to conclude, in accordance with Nezlek and Kuppens (2008) that negative emotions mobilize more although less successful regulation. People may be forced to seek the most successful form of regulation of negative affect among many diverse strategies, and this may imply many trials. Finally, confirming a differential use of affect regulation forms in positive vs. negative episodes, comparison of the effectiveness of affect regulation forms suggest that in the case of anger and sadness effective strategies have similar strength of association with the attainment of adaptive goals.

The results also show that adaptive forms are reported at higher levels than maladaptive forms (as revealed by the means in Table 1 and confirmed by a *t*-test not shown in this paper), the former being strongly related to episodic emotional adjustment. However, a meta-analysis of emotional regulation in depression and anxiety, which applied psychopathological measures and clinical samples, found large correlational effect sizes for problem-directed action and planning as related to psychopathology, but also a large effect size for maladaptive regulation such as inhibition and suppression, and smaller ones for adaptive reappraisal and acceptance (Aldao et al., 2010). This suggests that our results are probably valid only for samples of healthy young people and for well-being measures.

Some of the results confirmed the fit of regulation strategies with emotional action tendencies. In line with the ‘approach emotion’ character of both, there was more confrontation in anger and joy than in a ‘resignation’ emotion such as sadness. However, despite its nature as an externalizing emotion whose function is to remove obstacles, there was more regulated expression, greater social comparison and more physiological

regulation in the case of anger, reflecting a greater attempt at controlling the action tendency. As for the case of joy, the lower problem-directed action and planning, seeking instrumental support, rumination and self-control appear to reflect not the tendency of positive affect to broaden and build resources (Fredrickson, 2009), but rather simply the fact that positive affect is better accepted.

General adaptive forms of regulation

One of the most important findings of this study is that a variety of affect regulation forms were confirmed to be applied and adaptive in both negative and positive emotional episodes. As concerns the forms that reflect modification of situation, in accordance with previous meta-analyses and other studies (Compass et al., 2001; Skinner et al., 2003), problem-directed action and planning and seeking instrumental support were associated in all emotional episodes with perceived attainment of adaptive goals and dispositional reappraisal. Planning is probably related to avoidance of negative situations or prevention of strong negative arousal in negative emotional episodes, and together with direct action should improve perception of control, self-efficacy and self-esteem, as well as global well-being. Direct action in joy was associated with psychological well-being.

As for attentional deployment, acceptance and gratitude were functional in both positive and negative emotional episodes and associated with dispositional reappraisal, suggesting that these forms of positive attentional deployment are universally adaptative. Similarly, gratitude or self-reward in joy was associated with psychological well-being, in congruence with studies on affect regulation and well-being (Lyubomirsky, 2008).

Cognitive change regulation strategies like rumination and positive reappraisal were also functional in both positive and negative emotional episodes and associated with dispositional reappraisal, suggesting that these forms of cognitive change are universally adaptative as well, because they involve cognitive reflection and change of perspective, in line with the results of the meta-analysis by Augustine and Hemenover (2009). Moreover, rumination in joy was associated with psychological well-being, perhaps because the items used in the present study reflected in a great extent pondering and reflexive understanding of emotions (Aldao et al., 2010). This may explain the positive role of rumination in this study, more akin to emotional processing (Stanton et al., 2000) than to repetitive ruminative cognitions in anger and sadness.

Such findings overall indicate that positive attentional deployment and cognitive processing allow individuals to assimilate and reframe the experience and that an increase in attribution of meaning reinforces well-being, particularly in the case of positive affect. These results are consistent with findings of experimental studies

showing that positive moods predispose individuals to feel that life is meaningful and increase sensitivity to attribute meaning to situations (King, Hicks, Krull, & Del Gaiso, 2006).

As regards forms of modulation of emotional response, active physiological regulation, self-control related to acceptance, and self-reward related to gratitude, were associated with attainment of adaptive goals in general, also as found in previous studies (Aldao et al., 2010; Augustine & Hemenover, 2009; Moskowitz et al., 2009; Thayer, 1998). One explanation of these findings might be that such responses increase self-efficacy and self-esteem and therefore fuel positive emotions. Passive physiological regulation was in turn associated with adaptive goals only in joy, probably because it may imply eating and drinking related to simultaneous socialization and socialization is related to positive affect (Fredrickson, 2009). Finally, regulated expression was in a similar way associated with attainment of adaptive goals in general, as expected, confirming that assertive but not confrontational verbal expression helps to strengthen positive relations with others, perception of control and well being (Stanton et al., 2000).

Adaptive forms in anger and joy

Seeking emotional and informative social support were functional in the anger and joy episodes, and associated with adaptive dispositional regulation through reappraisal, whereas seeking emotional social support was negatively related to dispositional suppression (Gross et al., 2006). These results for social support related forms of regulation are congruent with those of previous studies (Paez et al., 2012a) and meta-analyses (Moskowitz et al., 2009), confirming that the presence of others which validates emotions, receiving good advice, and reinforcing self-esteem through external feedback facilitates cognitive restructuration of emotional experience and strengthens well-being.

In addition, affect regulation both through spiritual activities and humor were adaptive in the joy and anger emotional episodes. Regulation through spiritual activities reflects 'finding the positive meaning' typical for reappraisal and is thus associated with adaptive goals, congruently with studies on religious regulation (Moskowitz et al., 2009). Humor in turn may be found to play a functional role in joy because it is associated with dispositional reappraisal, as expected based on previous findings (Martin, 2007). Overall, these findings confirm that the activation of contrary emotions decreases anger (Kennedy-Moore & Watson, 1999) and that probably humor helps to increase affiliation and therefore emphasizes joy.

Adaptive forms in joy

A series of affect regulation strategies, such as wishful thinking, helping others, passive physiological regulation, venting and confrontation were associated with adaptive

outcomes only in joy. For instance, the positive role of affect regulation through wishful thinking, associated in the joy episode with dispositional reappraisal, provides support to the assertion that mental traveling involving a positive situation, such as a joyful event, is an adaptive form of affective regulation (Quoidbach et al., 2010). Similarly, altruism was found to be adaptive in joy, probably because warm interaction and prosocial behavior have positive effects (Lyubomirsky et al., 2005), such as facilitating building resources, as suggested by studies on the transmission of happiness in networks and on the broaden-and-build effects of positive affect (Fredrickson, 2009).

Passive physiological regulation is also an adaptive form of regulation in the case of joy, perhaps because it mostly refers to such activities as eating and drinking in social contexts that are related to positive affect. In fact, eating while socializing is commonly considered to be one of the most pleasurable moments of the day (Csikszentmihalyi, 1997). Venting and confrontation were also, as expected, associated with adaptive goals in the joy episode, whereas this result is not valid for negative emotions. Functional role of venting and confrontation in joy is in line with the hypothesis that the intense expression of emotions (in particular toward those who are responsible for them) intensifies those emotions (Kennedy-Moore & Watson, 1999). In this case that would be positive affect (Rimé, 2009), and therefore, it is considered to be a functional outcome because a desired positive emotion is being intensified.

Surprisingly, also distraction was positively associated with attainment of adaptive goals in joy, as well as with dispositional reappraisal, at odds with some studies (Quoidbach et al., 2010). It is important to bear in mind that in the previous literature, the negative effect of distraction in joy was explained by the fact that it diverted attention from positive feelings and therefore prevented one from savoring positive events and affect (Quoidbach et al., 2010). However, in this study, regulation of joy through distraction may have implied focusing on positive stimuli (the items referred to having fun or some relaxing activities), and this could explain why it is not detrimental but reinforcing positive affect.

Maladaptive forms of regulation

Whereas most of the forms of affect regulation seem to be functional depending on the emotional context, such strategies as psychological abandonment, social isolation, and suppression of emotion were universally maladaptive independently of the type of emotional experience. Psychological abandonment was negatively associated with adaptive goals in general, whereas social isolation was negatively related to adjustment in anger (but not related to adaptive goals in other types of emotional episodes). Moreover, both psychological abandonment and social isolation were linked with dispositional suppression, and

social isolation also with low psychological well-being. These findings suggest that psychological abandonment and social isolation as forms of regulation which reflect avoidance are maladaptive also in the long term (Larsen & Prizmic, 2008), which could be attributed to the fact that these strategies impede receiving social support and socializing overall, as well as obstaculize assertive forms of action.

Suppression of emotional expression was in turn negatively associated with adaptive goals in the case of emotional experience of sadness, as well as it was linked with low PWB and dispositional suppression. These results are in accordance with the previous findings from a longitudinal study concerning the daily affect (Nezlek & Kuppens, 2008), and reinforce the idea that suppression increases negative low-activation emotions, such as sadness. The nonexpression of sadness probably impedes the receipt of social support – and this may explain the negative outcome of such regulation of this emotional experience. The lack of negative association of suppression with adaptive goals in joy is intriguing, but the previous literature does not support the relationship between suppression and a weakening of positive affect either (Christophe et al., 2009). Perhaps, suppression is not detrimental in joy as compared to sadness because an important element in the nonexpression of negative episodes is faking opposite emotions, perceived as unauthentic and therefore eliciting social rejection (Mikolajczak, 2009). Moderate nonexpression of a positive emotion and faking neutral faces may not be strongly maladaptive.

Finally, social comparison was not negatively related to adaptive goals and psychological well-being; this is at odds with the findings of some studies but in any case the relationship was not positive, which is in line with the literature (Fujita, 2008).

Undoubtedly, this study is not devoid of limitations. First, the sample consists of young students (mainly female), and the findings cannot be therefore generalized. Also, measuring affect regulation with retrospective self-reports is another limitation because self-reported emotion regulation is not the same as actual measurement of affect regulation on-line. Finally, given the cross-sectional design of the study, the causal link between regulation and improvement in pleasantness, understanding and control cannot be established. Nevertheless, our results are globally congruent with the findings of both experimental (Augustine & Hemenover, 2009) and longitudinal studies (Nezlek & Kuppens, 2008), as well as with these from meta-analyses (Aldao et al., 2010).

Conclusion

The present study demonstrated that state episodic measures provide some relevant information for regulation of affect, particularly for joy and positive affect. The results of the current research also reveal that some forms of

adaptive regulation are frequently used at the same level in joy, anger, and sadness. The findings concerning the differences in the frequency of use of the most strategies are not at odds with the fact that problem-directed action and planning, rumination, and gratitude/self-reward and low psychological abandonment or withdrawal (and to a lesser extent low social isolation and suppression) are related to episodic adaptive goals. These forms could be convened as the forms of regulation at the core of positive affect functional regulation.

Regulation of positive emotion is less intense but more successful than in the case of negative emotion. However, the core of adaptive regulation is importantly common to positive and negative affect. Future research on affect regulation should put more emphasis on the positive emotional episodes, and expand the findings of this study to other positive emotional experiences such as pride, inspiration, love, or interest.

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